

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Do-not-use advisory

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Do not drink or use tap water for any purpose while a do-not-use advisory is in effect. Avoid contact with skin, eyes and lungs. Use commercially bottled or officially approved alternatives and follow local instructions for sanitation.

Do now.

**Stop tap-water use**

01

Do not bathe, wash dishes or use connected water and ice appliances.

**Get safe alternatives**

02

Check official water distribution and hygiene arrangements.

**Prevent accidental exposure**

03

Tell everyone in the household and keep children and pets from using taps.

**Follow restoration steps**

04

Wait for the official all-clear and complete any required flushing or appliance instructions.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Make the unsafe supply physically obvious with signs and tell every person in the household. Use a separate clean-water container for essential washing. Avoid flushing or other contact unless the advisory specifically permits it; find another sanitation arrangement.

Watch for.

Boiling does not override a do-not-use order.

People & practical needs.

Make the restriction visible at every affected tap and brief every caregiver. Plan safe hygiene for infants, wounds, mobility needs and pets. Avoid carrying restricted water through clean food-preparation areas.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Plan temporary access to safe washing and sanitation if restrictions continue.

Questions in the field.

What does a complete use restriction mean?

Avoid the restricted water for drinking, cooking, washing and other uses covered by the notice. Some hazards involve contact or vapor as well as ingestion. Use an alternate source and do not test the water yourself by smell, taste or a home filter.

What if I cannot wash or flush normally?

Keep clean drinking water separate from dirty-water handling. Follow the restriction and the sanitation fallback in Emergency hygiene and Sewer failure. A bucket or cleaning product cannot override a chemical exposure restriction.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Do-not-use advisory · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/drinking-water-advisories-an-overview.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/do-not-use/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.